

CUES & AP QUESTIONS

NOTES

Why was South/SE Asia a trade crossroads?

Name 3 major empires/states in this chapter.

What religions competed for influence in this region?

AP EXAM TIP

South/SE Asia = where the Indian Ocean trade network connected East Asia, the Islamic world, and Africa. Every AP essay on Indian Ocean trade should reference this region.

What is Sinification? What is Indianization?

CCOT theme:

What CHANGED in SE Asia between 1200 and 1450?

Why did Islam spread to SE Asia by 1450?

GEOGRAPHIC SIGNIFICANCE

South and Southeast Asia occupy the center of Indian Ocean trade. India's coasts face both the Arabian Sea (west, toward the Islamic world) and the Bay of Bengal (east, toward SE Asia and China). The Strait of Malacca — between the Malay Peninsula and Sumatra — is the single chokepoint through which all trade between the Indian Ocean and South China Sea must pass.

MAJOR STATES AND EMPIRES

- › **Delhi Sultanate** (1206–1526) — Islamic rule in northern India
- › **Vijayanagara Empire** (1336–1646) — Hindu kingdom in southern India; resisted Islamic expansion
- › **Khmer Empire** (802–1431) — Hindu-Buddhist empire in mainland SE Asia; built Angkor Wat
- › **Srivijaya** (650–1377) — Buddhist maritime empire controlling Strait of Malacca
- › **Majapahit** (1293–c.1527) — Hindu-Buddhist empire in Java, replaced Srivijaya

RELIGIONS IN COMPETITION

- › **Hinduism:** Deep roots in India; spread to SE Asia via merchants and Brahmin advisors; Angkor Wat (Khmer) is the world's largest Hindu temple
- › **Buddhism:** Spread from India throughout SE Asia; Theravada Buddhism dominant in mainland SE Asia by 1450
- › **Islam:** Arriving via Indian Ocean trade routes by the 1200s; Malacca (founded c. 1400) becomes a Muslim sultanate and key trading hub
- › **Syncretism:** Hindu, Buddhist, and local traditions blended throughout the region

INDIANIZATION — Cultural Diffusion from India

Process by which Indian cultural models (Sanskrit language, Hindu/Buddhist religion, political ideas of divine kingship) spread to SE Asia via merchants, Brahmin advisors, and traders — without Indian conquest. Parallel to China's **Sinification** of Korea/Japan/Vietnam. Both show that cultural power ≠ military conquest.

AP TIP: South/SE Asia is the AP exam's prime example of religious syncretism and cultural diffusion via trade. Know: Angkor Wat (Hindu → Buddhist), Srivijaya (Buddhist), and Islam's arrival via merchants by 1300s.

SUMMARY — Write the main idea of this page in your own words:

South and Southeast Asia = the Indian Ocean's crossroads, where Islamic, Hindu, Buddhist, and Chinese influences intersected. **Indianization** spread Hindu-Buddhist culture to SE Asia via trade (parallel to Sinification). By 1450, **Islam was arriving via merchant networks**, beginning a religious shift that would transform the region in Unit 2. Key chokepoint: **Strait of Malacca**.

CUES & AP QUESTIONS

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How was the Delhi Sultanate founded?

Who were the Mamluks of Delhi?

Did Islam spread widely under Delhi rule?

AP EXAM TIP

Delhi Sultanate = Islamic political rule over a Hindu majority. Use it to show that Islamic political control did NOT equal mass forced conversion. Muslims remained a minority in India throughout.

How did the Delhi Sultanate stop the Mongols?

What role did Sufism play in India under Delhi rule?

COMMON MISTAKE

Do NOT say 'Islam conquered India.' The Delhi Sultanate conquered northern India politically but most of the population remained Hindu. Southern India (Vijayanagara) remained independent and Hindu.

FOUNDING OF THE DELHI SULTANATE (1206)

Emerging from the Ghurid invasions of northern India. **Qutb-ud-Din Aibak**, a former Turkish slave-soldier (Mamluk) of the Ghurid sultan, established the sultanate after his master's death. First of five successive dynasties that ruled from Delhi. The Qutb Minar minaret (Delhi) still stands as an architectural symbol of the sultanate's founding.

GOVERNANCE AND RELIGION

- › Sultans ruled as Muslims over a majority Hindu population
- › **Jizya tax** imposed on non-Muslims (dhimmis) — controversial; some sultans enforced strictly, others loosely
- › Hindus retained religious and cultural autonomy in most areas; temples sometimes destroyed for political intimidation but not systematic elimination
- › Persian became the court language; Islamic architecture introduced alongside existing Hindu styles
- › **Ulama** served as judges and legal advisors; Hindu scholars maintained Sanskrit traditions

SUFISM IN INDIA — Most Effective at Spreading Islam

- › **Chishti order**: Most influential Sufi order in India; established lodges (khanqahs) that served as community centers
- › Sufis often learned local languages, incorporated Indian music and poetry, and served lower-caste communities
- › Created Hindu-Muslim syncretic spaces — e.g., joint veneration of Sufi saints by Hindus and Muslims
- › More effective than political imposition at gaining voluntary converts

REPELLING THE MONGOLS

The Delhi Sultanate successfully repelled multiple Mongol invasions of northern India (early-mid 1200s to early 1300s). This is historically significant: **India escaped the devastation that the Mongols inflicted on Persia, Iraq, and China.** The Delhi Sultanate's military strength (heavily fortified cities, war elephants, large armies) made it a difficult target.

VIJAYANAGARA EMPIRE (1336–1646) — The Hindu Counter

Founded in southern India as a **Hindu kingdom resisting Delhi's expansion southward**. Patron of Hindu temples, Sanskrit literature, and classical arts. Controlled spice and cotton trade with the Indian Ocean network. Its existence shows that Islamic political expansion in India had firm geographic limits — the south remained Hindu.

AP TIP: Use the Delhi Sultanate + Vijayanagara contrast to argue that South Asia was a zone of religious coexistence under political tension — not uniform Islamization. This is a high-scoring complexity argument.

SUMMARY — Write the main idea of this page in your own words:

Delhi Sultanate (1206–1526) = first major Islamic state in South Asia, founded by Turkish Mamluk soldiers. Political Islam ≠ mass conversion: Hindus remained the majority. **Sufis** (especially Chishti order) were far more effective at winning converts than political coercion. The Delhi Sultanate successfully repelled Mongol invasions, protecting India from Mongol devastation. **Vijayanagara** in the south remained a Hindu counterpower.

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What made the Indian Ocean trade self-sustaining?

Strait of Malacca

Where? Why critical?

Who were the main participants in Indian Ocean trade?

What goods moved in each direction?

AP EXAM TIP

The Indian Ocean trade network was the world's largest and most consistent long-distance trade system. On AP essays, always name: (1) monsoon winds as mechanism, (2) Muslim merchants as dominant agents, (3) goods flowing in each direction.

How did India's position make it a trade hub?

What is an entrepot? Give an example.

COMMON MISTAKE

The Indian Ocean network was NOT controlled by any single empire — it was decentralized, driven by private merchants using shared commercial conventions (sharia contracts, Arabic as a trade language).

THE MONSOON ENGINE

Indian Ocean trade was made possible and regular by the **monsoon wind system**. Summer monsoons blow northeast (June–September) carrying sailors from Arabia/Africa toward India and SE Asia. Winter monsoons reverse (November–March), enabling the return journey. This predictable annual cycle made round-trip voyages reliable — and created an annual rhythm of commerce.

PARTICIPANTS AND THEIR ROLES

- › **Arab/Persian merchants:** Dominated the western Indian Ocean; operated dhows; spread Islam
- › **Indian merchants (Gujarati, Tamil):** Key middlemen connecting western and eastern Indian Ocean
- › **Chinese merchants:** Operated in the South China Sea and SE Asian waters; Zheng He's voyages extended into the Indian Ocean
- › **Malay merchants (Srivijaya/Majapahit):** Controlled Strait of Malacca; taxed passing trade
- › **Swahili Coast merchants:** Exported African goods (gold, ivory, enslaved people)

KEY GOODS AND TRADE FLOWS

- › **Westbound (toward Arabia/Africa):** Spices (cloves, nutmeg from Spice Islands/Maluku), silks (China), porcelain (China), cotton textiles (India)
- › **Eastbound (toward India/SE Asia):** Gold (Africa/Arabia), horses (Arabia/Central Asia — critical for Indian military), glassware, dates
- › **From SE Asia:** Tropical spices (most valuable commodity — weight for weight, more valuable than gold in Europe)

ENTREPOTS — Trading Hub Cities

- › **Calicut (India):** Premier spice market on the Malabar Coast; cosmopolitan port
- › **Malacca (SE Asia, founded c. 1400):** Controlled the Strait; became a Muslim sultanate; merchants from 80+ languages reportedly traded there
- › **Kilwa (East Africa):** Richest Swahili Coast city; taxed gold trade from interior Zimbabwe
- › **Hormuz (Persian Gulf):** Gateway between Indian Ocean and Middle East

INDIA AS TRADE HUB

India sat at the center of Indian Ocean trade geographically. **Cotton textiles** were India's most important export — affordable and practical, traded across the entire network. India imported horses (essential for the Delhi Sultanate's military) and exported cotton cloth, spices, and indigo dye. The Indian subcontinent served as the midpoint between the western Islamic world and the eastern Chinese/SE Asian networks.

AP TIP: For any comparison of trade networks, note that the Indian Ocean was decentralized and merchant-driven (unlike the tribute-based Silk Roads or the state-managed Chinese tribute system). This distinction = analytical sophistication.

SUMMARY — Write the main idea of this page in your own words:

Indian Ocean trade ran on **monsoon winds** — predictable, annual, enabling reliable round trips. Participants: Arab/Persian merchants (western), Indian merchants (middle), Malay (Strait of Malacca), Swahili Coast (African goods). Key goods: spices (SE Asia), textiles (India), gold (Africa). **Entrepots** like Calicut, Malacca, and Kilwa were commercial hubs. Network was decentralized — no single empire controlled it.

CUES & AP QUESTIONS

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Khmer Empire

Location? Religion? Dates? Key monument?

Angkor Wat

What is it? What does it reveal about Khmer society?

Srivijaya

What type of state? How did it generate wealth?

AP EXAM TIP

Angkor Wat is AP World History's best example of: (1) Indianization, (2) Hindu-Buddhist syncretism, (3) state use of religious monument-building for legitimacy. Know all three uses.

Majapahit

How did it differ from Srivijaya?

COMMON MISTAKE

Angkor Wat was originally a **HINDU** temple, then converted to Buddhist use. Do not call it simply a Buddhist temple. This syncretism is precisely the AP point.

How was Theravada Buddhism different from Mahayana?

KHMER EMPIRE (802–1431) — Mainland SE Asia

- › Centered in modern-day Cambodia; controlled mainland SE Asia
- › Hindu-Buddhist state; kings legitimized rule as divine representatives (devaraja — 'god-king')
- › Economy based on intensive rice agriculture (elaborate irrigation systems fed large population)
- › **Angkor Wat** (built c. 1113–1150): World's largest religious monument; originally dedicated to Hindu god Vishnu; later converted to Theravada Buddhist use
- › Angkor's hydraulic engineering (reservoirs called barays) fed rice paddies supporting ~1 million people
- › **Decline:** Abandoned Angkor c. 1431 after Thai (Ayutthaya) attacks and possible climate/drought stress

ANGKOR WAT — AP Significance

- › **Indianization:** Sanskrit inscriptions, Hindu iconography, Indian architectural style all imported via trade contact
- › **Syncretism:** Hindu temple repurposed for Buddhist worship — shows religious flexibility
- › **State power:** Massive monument construction = mobilization of labor (like the Great Wall or Egyptian pyramids) = display of royal authority
- › **AP essay use:** Evidence for all three themes above; excellent for CCOT on religion in SE Asia

SRIVIJAYA (650–1377) — Maritime Buddhist Empire

- › Based in Sumatra; controlled the **Strait of Malacca** and taxed all passing trade
- › **Buddhist** state — was a center of Buddhist learning; monks traveled from China/India to study there
- › Generated wealth through **toll collection** on Indian Ocean trade passing through the strait
- › Declined as rivals (Chola kingdom of India, then Majapahit) challenged its control

MAJAPAHIT (1293–c.1527) — Hindu-Buddhist Java

- › Based in Java; rose after Srivijaya's decline; briefly controlled much of island SE Asia
- › Hindu-Buddhist state; patronized Sanskrit literature and Hindu court culture
- › Extensive maritime trade connections; one of the last major Hindu-Buddhist states before Islam's arrival
- › **By 1450:** Islam was beginning to arrive via Muslim merchants in coastal trading cities; Majapahit's interior remained Hindu-Buddhist

THERAVADA BUDDHISM IN MAINLAND SE ASIA

By 1200–1450, **Theravada Buddhism** (the 'older school,' emphasizing the Pali canon and individual monastic practice) was spreading through mainland SE Asia (Burma, Thailand, Cambodia, Laos). This contrasted with **Mahayana Buddhism** dominant in East Asia (China, Korea, Japan) and **Vajrayana (Tibetan)** in Central Asia. The spread of Theravada marked a religious shift in the region.

SUMMARY — Write the main idea of this page in your own words:

SE Asian states were shaped by **Indianization** (Hindu-Buddhist cultural diffusion via trade). **Khmer Empire** built Angkor Wat — world's largest religious monument; originally Hindu, converted to Buddhist use. **Srivijaya** taxed Strait of Malacca trade; Buddhist maritime state. **Majapahit** replaced Srivijaya in Java. By 1450, **Islam was arriving via coastal trade** — the beginning of a major religious transformation.

CUES & AP QUESTIONS

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Define religious syncretism. Give 3 examples from Ch. 3.

How did Buddhism spread to SE Asia?

How was Islam's arrival in SE Asia different from its arrival in the Middle East?

AP EXAM TIP

Religious syncretism in SE Asia = top AP evidence for: (1) cultural diffusion via trade, (2) local adaptation of world religions, (3) CCOT — religions CHANGE as they spread. Use Angkor Wat (Hindu-Buddhist), Sufism in India, and Malacca (Hindu-turned-Muslim sultanate) as three examples.

Malacca

Why did its ruler convert to Islam? What were the consequences?

COMMON MISTAKE

When Islam arrives in SE Asia, it does NOT erase Hindu-Buddhist culture immediately. Syncretism persists — local customs blend with Islamic practice. This process takes centuries.

What role did trade diasporas play in religious spread?

RELIGIOUS SYNCRETISM IN SOUTH/SE ASIA

South and Southeast Asia are AP World History's best examples of religious blending. Because religions arrived via trade rather than conquest, local populations adopted new beliefs while retaining older practices. Three key examples:

- › **Angkor Wat:** Built as a Hindu temple, converted to Buddhist worship — same monument, two religions
- › **Indian Sufism:** Chishti Sufi shrines venerated by both Muslims and Hindus; shared sacred spaces
- › **SE Asian Islam:** Arriving Muslim merchants intermarried with local elites; mosques incorporated local architectural styles; pre-Islamic customs (ancestor veneration, elaborate death rituals) persisted alongside Islamic worship

BUDDHISM'S SPREAD TO SE ASIA

- › **Theravada Buddhism:** Spread from Sri Lanka to mainland SE Asia (Burma, Thailand, Cambodia) via monks and merchants
- › **Mahayana Buddhism:** Had earlier influence in island SE Asia via Indian and Chinese merchants
- › **Mechanism:** Monks traveled on merchant ships; Buddhist monasteries received patronage from rulers seeking legitimacy and literacy
- › Buddhism blended with animist and Hindu traditions — e.g., Khmer kings incorporated both Shiva worship and Buddhist veneration

MALACCA — The Pivot Point (c. 1400)

- › Founded c. 1400 on the Malay Peninsula by a Srivijayan prince (**Parameswara**)
- › Strategically located at the Strait of Malacca — became the region's busiest entrepot
- › **Ruler converted to Islam c. 1414** — motivated by desire to attract Muslim merchants and gain protection from Majapahit
- › Malacca's conversion began the Islamization of island SE Asia — sultanate model spread to coastal Javanese, Sumatran, and Philippine cities
- › **AP significance:** Islam spread to SE Asia via *political conversion for commercial advantage*, not military conquest — same pattern as Mali in Africa

TRADE DIASPORA COMMUNITIES

Muslim merchants who settled permanently in SE Asian ports formed **diaspora communities** — maintaining Islamic practice while adapting to local culture. They built mosques, applied sharia to trade contracts, and often intermarried with local women (whose children were Muslim). Over generations, these communities grew and their religion spread from coastal trading cities inward.

AP TIP: Across the entire AP course, religious syncretism appears in: SE Asia (Hindu-Buddhist-Islam), West Africa (Islam + indigenous traditions), Latin America (Catholic + indigenous), and East Asia (Buddhism + Shinto/Confucianism). Recognize the pattern.

SUMMARY — Write the main idea of this page in your own words:

Religious syncretism = religions adopting local elements as they spread. In SE Asia: **Angkor Wat** (Hindu-Buddhist), **Sufi shrines** in India (Muslim-Hindu), **Malacca's conversion** (c. 1414 — commercial motivation, not conquest). Islam arrived via **trade diaspora communities** in coastal cities, not military invasion. Theravada Buddhism spread through mainland SE Asia via monks on merchant ships.

CUES & AP QUESTIONS

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Caste system (varna):

What are the 4 varnas? What is Jati?

How did the caste system limit merchants?

How did Buddhist and Islamic merchants bypass caste restrictions?

AP EXAM TIP

AP essays on social structures should compare India's caste system to China's Confucian hierarchy and Islamic society's treatment of merchants. Note that Islam elevated merchants' status while Confucianism and the caste system formally ranked them low.

How were women's roles shaped by religion in this chapter?

COMMON MISTAKE

The caste system was not static or uniformly enforced. Jati (sub-castes) were more important in daily life than the 4-varna theory. And merchants often circumvented caste by converting to Buddhism or Islam.

What was the role of the Brahmin class?

THE VARNA SYSTEM — India's Social Hierarchy

- › **Brahmins** (priests/scholars) — highest caste; keepers of Sanskrit knowledge and religious ritual
- › **Kshatriyas** (warriors/rulers) — political and military authority
- › **Vaishyas** (merchants/farmers) — commercial and agricultural producers
- › **Shudras** (servants/laborers) — lowest caste; service roles
- › **Dalits** ('untouchables') — outside the varna system; performed 'polluting' work
- › **Jati** = occupational sub-castes; determined who one could eat with, marry, and work alongside in daily life — more practically important than the 4 varna categories

MERCHANTS IN THE CASTE SYSTEM

Vaishyas (merchants) ranked third — above servants but below warriors and priests. This formally low status contrasted with their often enormous actual wealth. Some merchants **converted to Buddhism or Islam** to escape caste restrictions — both religions offered more egalitarian frameworks for commercial activity.

BRAHMINS — Cultural Power Beyond India

Brahmin advisors traveled to SE Asian courts where they helped legitimize rulers through Hindu ritual, Sanskrit language, and cosmological traditions. This was a key mechanism of **Indianization** — Brahmin expertise was so valuable that SE Asian rulers imported it voluntarily. Angkor Wat's Sanskrit inscriptions reflect Brahmin influence.

GENDER AND SOCIAL STRUCTURES

- › **Hindu practice:** Sati (widow self-immolation on husband's funeral pyre) — practiced among upper castes; reflects extreme patriarchal control. Not universal but present
- › **Islamic practice in India:** Purdah (seclusion of women) adopted by upper-class Muslim women; jizya imposed on non-Muslim men — women in different legal position
- › **SE Asia:** Women generally had higher status than in South Asia — active in trade, property ownership, and sometimes political roles; pre-Islamic matrilineal traditions persisted in parts of SE Asia
- › **Buddhist practice:** Theoretically more egalitarian; nuns' orders existed, though with lower status than monks

COMPARISON: SOCIAL HIERARCHIES ACROSS UNIT 1

- › **India (varna/caste):** Hereditary, religiously sanctioned hierarchy; merchants ranked low
- › **China (Confucian):** Scholar-gentry at top; merchants ranked lowest
- › **Islamic world:** Merchants respected (the Prophet Muhammad was a merchant); social mobility possible through religious knowledge
- › **Feudal Europe:** Clergy, nobility, commoners — merchants emerging but not yet high status

AP TIP: Comparing how different societies ranked merchants is a high-yield AP analysis. India and China formally ranked them low despite their economic importance. Islam elevated them. This comparison appears in both LEQ and DBQ prompts.

SUMMARY — Write the main idea of this page in your own words:

India's **varna system** formally ranked merchants third; **jati** (sub-castes) governed daily social interaction. **Brahmins** exported Hindu ritual expertise to SE Asian courts (Indianization). Gender: SE Asian women had more autonomy than South Asian women; Hindu sati and Islamic purdah both reflect patriarchal control. Key comparison: India and China rank merchants low; Islam treats them with respect — use this in social structure essays.

CUES & AP QUESTIONS	NOTES
CCOT Framework: <i>3 continuities and 3 changes for Ch. 3</i> <i>Top 3 AP essay prompts for Ch. 3:</i> <i>Key comparisons for Ch. 3 essays:</i> AP EXAM TIP Angkor Wat and Malacca are your two anchor examples for Ch. 3. Angkor = Indianization + syncretism. Malacca = Islam via trade, not conquest. Both appear frequently in AP stimuli. COMMON MISTAKES (1) Saying Islam 'conquered' SE Asia. (2) Calling Angkor Wat just 'Buddhist.' (3) Forgetting that the Strait of Malacca is the Indian Ocean's key chokepoint. (4) Confusing Srivijaya (Buddhist maritime) with Majapahit (Hindu-Buddhist Java). <i>Terms to define in essays:</i>	CCOT FRAMEWORK FOR CHAPTER 3 › CONTINUITIES: Indian Ocean trade routes active throughout Hindu and Buddhist traditions in SE Asia (even as Islam arrives) Caste system in India Muslim merchant dominance of Indian Ocean › CHANGES: Delhi Sultanate introduces Islamic political rule to India (1206) Srivijaya's decline; Majapahit's rise Malacca's founding and conversion to Islam (c. 1400–1414) Theravada Buddhism spreading across mainland SE Asia › COMPLEXITY: Islamic arrival = syncretism, not replacement of Hindu-Buddhist culture; local customs persisted TOP AP ESSAY PROMPTS › 1. LEQ: 'Analyze the role of trade in spreading religion across the Indian Ocean world 1200–1450.' → Use Muslim merchants spreading Islam + Buddhist monks on trade ships + Sufi missionaries in India › 2. SAQ: 'Explain ONE cause and ONE effect of the spread of Buddhism to Southeast Asia.' → Cause: Indian merchants/monks; Effect: Angkor Wat, Theravada spread through mainland SE Asia › 3. DBQ: 'Evaluate the extent to which the Indian Ocean trade network transformed the cultures of its participants.' → Use Angkor Wat (Indianization), Malacca conversion (Islamization via trade), syncretism as key concept KEY AP-READY COMPARISONS › Indianization vs. Sinification: Both = cultural diffusion from a dominant civilization to neighbors via trade, without military conquest; Indian model spread religion, Chinese model spread governance/literacy › Indian caste hierarchy vs. Chinese Confucian hierarchy: Both formally ranked merchants low despite commercial importance; different religious justifications › Malacca's conversion vs. Mali's conversion: Both rulers converted to Islam for commercial advantages; both show Islam spreading via trade networks › Angkor Wat vs. Forbidden City: Both demonstrate state power through monumental architecture; different religious traditions KEY TERMS TO DEFINE Indianization Syncretism Entrepot Strait of Malacca Monsoon Dhow Theravada Buddhism Varna Jati Brahmin Devaraja Diaspora community Srivijaya Majapahit Khmer Empire Delhi Sultanate COMPLEXITY POINT STRATEGY Argue that religious change in SE Asia was gradual and syncretic — Islam did not erase Hindu-Buddhist culture but layered on top of it. By 1450, coastal cities were Muslim while interiors remained Hindu-Buddhist. This regional variation within a broader trend = complexity point on any DBQ or LEQ about religion's spread.
SUMMARY — Write the main idea of this page in your own words:	

Ch. 3 AP mastery: (1) **Indianization** = cultural diffusion via trade, not conquest (compare to Sinification); (2) **Angkor Wat** = best evidence for Hindu-Buddhist syncretism and state power through monumental architecture; (3) **Malacca's conversion** = Islam spread via commercial incentives, not conquest. The Strait of Malacca = Indian Ocean's critical chokepoint. Merchant status comparison (India/China vs. Islam) = high-yield for social structure essays.